



Bran Castle

Popularly known as Dracula's castle, a Gothic fortress and palace in the Carpathian mountains

For more than 600 years, Bran Castle has dominated a mountain pass on the border between the historic regions of Transylvania and Wallachia. Now in Romania, in the 14th century, it lay within the domains of the kings of Hungary. German settlers from Saxony built the castle, with royal permission, between 1377 and 1388. The tall, thick outer walls proved a necessary defensive feature; the fortress, on the exposed edge of Christian Europe, was vulnerable to the armies of the Muslim Ottoman Empire that rampaged northward from Turkey and the Balkans.

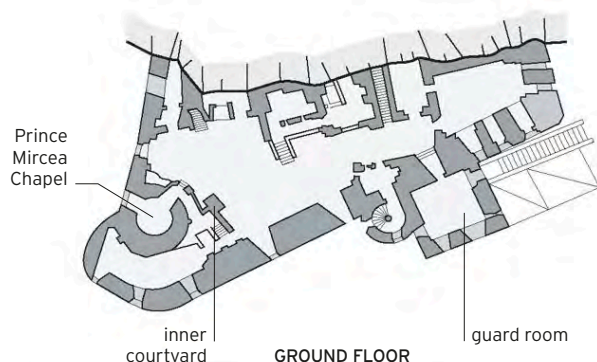
Dracula's castle?

The castle's association with Vlad III the Impaler, the notoriously cruel 15th-century ruler of Wallachia said to have inspired the blood-sucking fictional character Dracula, is dismissed by most historians as an invention of the modern tourist industry. Vlad the Impaler earned his nickname by impaling his enemies on pointed stakes. Dracula's creator, the Irish novelist Bram Stoker, never visited the castle. It is possible, however, that Vlad may have been imprisoned briefly in the castle's vaults in 1462.

After World War I, when the castle passed from Hungary to Romania, it became the favorite palace of the Romanian Queen Marie, who was attracted to its romantic solitude. The building now exhibits the queen's valuable collection of furniture and art. Although the castle's connection with Dracula may be fictitious, its haunting atmosphere and spectacular setting guarantee its place as one of Romania's most successful tourist destinations.

RESHAPING THE CASTLE

The original 14th-century fortress was built from wood and stone and had a skewed rectangular footprint; its walls were studded with fire holes, now converted into windows. The 16th century saw the building of new towers that transformed the building plan and the addition of glass windows and roof tiles.



Mystras

Perfectly preserved ruins of a medieval city on towering heights above the Spartan plain

In 1249, William of Villehardouin, a French crusader knight, built a castle at Mystras on Mount Taygetos in the Peloponnese, southern Greece. His fortress was absorbed into the Greek Byzantine Empire, and a town spread across the slopes. By the 14th century, Mystras was a flourishing center of culture and learning, its richly endowed monasteries and churches embellished with beautiful frescoes.

Eventual decline

From 1460, when it was taken over by the Ottoman Turks, the city went into decline. As a consequence, it changed little through the centuries until 1832, when the last of its shrinking population had abandoned the lofty mountain site. Mystras has survived as an almost perfect ensemble of late Byzantine architecture, both religious and secular. It has been a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1989.



◁ PERIBLEPTOS MONASTERY

Built into the side of a cliff, in the mid-14th century, the castlelike Peribleptos Monastery is one of many religious buildings in Mystras.

▽ MYSTRAS FROM ABOVE

Villehardouin's castle stands on the hilltop above Mystras, with the palace of the Byzantine rulers of the city—known as the Despots of Morea—below it.

